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Summarize the 1906 San Francisco Earthquake. What factors shaped the current landscape?

The **1906 San Francisco earthquake** was one of the most devastating natural disasters in U.S. history, striking Northern California on April 18, 1906.

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## 🔎 What happened

- A massive earthquake (estimated magnitude ~7.9) ruptured along the **San Andreas Fault** for about 300 miles.
- Shaking lasted less than a minute but caused widespread collapse of buildings across **San Francisco** and nearby areas.
- Broken gas lines ignited fires that burned for **three days**, destroying much of the city.

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## 💥 Impact

- Around **3,000 people died** and over **200,000 were left homeless**.
- About **80% of San Francisco** was destroyed, mostly due to fire rather than the quake itself.
- Infrastructure—water, roads, communications—failed, making firefighting and rescue extremely difficult.

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## 🧭 Factors that shaped today's landscape

### 1. Urban redesign and rebuilding

- The city was rapidly rebuilt, but many proposed grand redesigns were only partially implemented.
- Wider streets, improved building layouts, and better access routes were introduced in some areas.

### 2. Advances in earthquake science

- The disaster led to major research on fault movement and elastic rebound theory.
- It helped establish modern **seismology** in the U.S.

### 3. Stronger building codes

- New regulations required structures to better withstand shaking.
- Over time, this evolved into strict seismic building standards still used today across California.

### 4. Infrastructure improvements

- Recognition that fire caused most destruction led to:
  - Better water systems (e.g., auxiliary water supply for firefighting)
  - Stronger emergency response planning

### 5. Population and economic shifts

- Many residents temporarily relocated, and some businesses moved elsewhere in the Bay Area.
- However, San Francisco quickly reestablished itself as a major economic hub.

### 6. Lasting urban form

- Neighborhood patterns today—density, building styles, and some street layouts—reflect post-1906 rebuilding decisions.
- Use of more fire-resistant materials (brick, steel, reinforced concrete) became common.

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## 🧠 Big picture

The 1906 earthquake didn't just destroy San Francisco—it **reshaped how cities prepare for disasters**. Modern building codes, emergency planning, and earthquake science in

California all trace back to lessons learned from this event.

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If you want, I can compare it to later quakes like the **1989 Loma Prieta earthquake** and show how preparedness improved.

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